



**Nathan Butler**

Commercial & Operational Leadership

CLIENT CASE STUDIES

# What I Delivered for the Accounts Themselves

Winning a mandate is the easy part to talk about. This is what happened next: for the funds, housing associations, councils and developers who depended on the work actually being delivered, and for the people who bought and moved into the homes at the end of it. A large share of it was regeneration rather than greenfield: a former infirmary, a Victorian hospital, a listed dock warehouse and council-owned land brought forward for homes that were genuinely needed.

**c.4,500**

units, national accounts

**£1.1bn**

GDV overseen

**100%**

account retention, zero lost

**250**

office delivery network



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# Sanctuary: the Largest Account in the Group, Run as One

The largest account in the group by volume, spread across sites the length of the UK from a single Worcester head office. This is how it was run as one national programme, not a collection of local sales instructions, and why every tender since only grew stronger.

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**c.1,500** units won, the largest account in the group by volume

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## Situation

Sanctuary was the largest account in the group by volume, more completions running through it than any other client in the business, and it wasn't run from one office. Its own head office sat in Worcester, but its sales management teams were regional: a sales manager and a sales director in every part of the country I needed to work with, none of them reporting to me, running sites that were live and selling simultaneously in different parts of the UK.

The real stakes weren't sales figures alone. Sanctuary measured customer satisfaction directly from its own buyers, the people who had actually bought a home, and reported those scores to its own board, but that emphasis on satisfaction never softened how exactly they scrutinised sales performance itself. My delivery had to hold to both measures at once, not just to a sales number I was accountable for internally. A weak month on one site in one region wouldn't just cost a sale; it would show up in a report Sanctuary's board read every quarter, against a client whose name was on the door.

## The Leadership Challenge

None of the people whose cooperation I actually needed reported to me. Every regional sales manager and sales director inside Sanctuary had their own priorities, their own targets, and no obligation to make mine easier. Instruction wasn't an option: I could not tell a sales director three hundred miles away how to run their project. My own team was Sanctuary's sales team on every one of those sites, which meant I held both the sales numbers and the service standard directly, with Sanctuary holding performance to a standard every bit as exacting as the one its board applied to customer satisfaction. Taking that pressure, at every step, was part of the job. Making sure it never translated into how my own people were treated, or behaved, underneath me was the harder part. The only lever available was making my processes so obviously aligned with theirs, and my people so visibly good at the job, that working closely with me became the easier choice, not the compliant one.

That meant learning Sanctuary's own reporting standards well enough to anticipate them, not just respond to them. If their board wanted to see customer satisfaction trending a certain way, I needed to know that before a regional director had to raise it with me, training my own site teams to the standard Sanctuary's board expected, not the minimum a contract required.

## Approach

### Advice First, Then Delivery

Won the advisory mandate before a single sale was made: consultative input on site acquisition, pricing, specification and go-to-market strategy on new sites, shaping what got built as well as how it got sold. The operating model that followed was consistent everywhere: take the site from Sanctuary, resource it with my own salespeople, then wrap a sales management function around that team so delivery was never left to whoever happened to be on site that day.

### An Unofficial Veto on What Got Bought

Sanctuary never committed to a piece of land without me assessing it first: values, tenure mix, and whether the scheme actually made commercial sense. Nothing made that a requirement. No clause, no sign-off process, no step in any procurement document. It ran entirely on the trust built with Sanctuary's national sales director, who treated it as a conversation that happened as a matter of course rather than a step anyone had mandated. That informal check is why Sanctuary never ended up committed to stock I believed carried genuine risk.

## **A Layer of My Own**

Running that model across dozens of live sites nationally meant it could not be held together personally. I selected people from within my own organisation to act as regional sales managers, each one accountable for a number of Sanctuary sites and reporting directly to me: a structure that meant Sanctuary effectively had a dedicated Sales Director, fractionally, backed by a proper team rather than one person spread too thin. On top of that, local estate agency branch networks were engaged to drive incremental footfall to site, working to a deliberately stringent set of KPIs so performance could be monitored, measured and improved rather than left to hope.

## **Governance Behind the Scenes**

Setting a project like this up needed programme governance rather than a typical sales operation: defined workstreams across concurrent live sites, documented procedures, outputs recorded, and every person in the structure trained into their role, accountable at role level and clear on what they were responsible for. Sales reporting had to be frequent and accurate, not because the paperwork mattered for its own sake, but because it was the only way to run a national account strategically rather than reactively, region by region, without waiting for a problem to surface on its own.

## **Close to the Detail, Clear at the Top**

That governance gave me the ability to be close to the detail and operate at a high level at the same time: viewing numbers, staff attendance, sale trajectory on any individual site, without needing to ask. Most of the value in that closeness wasn't catching problems. It was recognising, early, that something was drifting before it became one.

## **Nothing Was Ever a Surprise**

I visited every site Sanctuary was building on personally. Understanding the micro-economics of a location, footfall patterns, local competition, the specific buyer profile a scheme would attract, and the macroeconomics around it meant a problem could be assessed and planned for before it occurred, not discovered afterwards. It made the whole relationship a better journey for Sanctuary, not just a better-managed one.

## **Staying Close While the Ground Moved**

Sanctuary's own strategy never stood still, and neither did their regional structure: reorganisations and reshaped teams more than once across the life of the relationship. The size of the account meant the right response wasn't always to push back immediately. More often it meant staying close enough to understand where they were actually heading, going along with the disruption while it played out, and choosing the moment to renegotiate rather than forcing one in the middle of it. Those conversations were approached calmly rather than as a complaint, and they were usually well received, because by then the relationship carried enough goodwill for Sanctuary to trust that the ask was reasonable.

## **Commercial Outcome**

Largest account in the group by volume, retained in full through every tender cycle, with the position strengthening each round rather than being defended each round. c.1,500 units won across the relationship.

## **Customer Outcome**

Satisfaction scored by Sanctuary's own buyers and reported to their own board. I was held to that measure rather than to a sales number, and trained my site teams to the standard their board expected rather than the minimum the contract required.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-sanctuary.html>

# WV Living: Translating Council Bureaucracy Into a Buyer's Journey

Wolverhampton City Council needed WV Living, its own housing development company, to prove that a genuinely social project could sell like a commercial one, across shared ownership, bulk sale to private rented sector investors and the open market, on sites from Hampton Park to Daisy Bank, with a sales operation built from a blank page, with no existing function to inherit.

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## 6 Sites Hampton Park to Daisy Bank, across Wolverhampton

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### Situation

Wolverhampton City Council set up WV Living as its own housing development company, because the ambition was never in question: genuinely needed homes, on sites like the former Northcote School at Hampton Park, the former Daisy Bank Community Centre in Bilston and the former Coseley Swimming Baths at Pear Tree Lane, three of many sites I sold across the programme. What was in question was whether a council-led company could sell what it built like a commercial developer, not just deliver it like a public body.

A council operates on process, sign-off and public accountability. A homebuyer operates on none of that: they want to know when they can view a plot, what their mortgage offer needs to look like, and when they get their keys. Between those two worlds sat a gap that nothing inside the council's own structure was built to close.

The ambition behind it was substantial, and specific. WV Living existed to do what the open market had declined to: develop the complex, vacant and derelict sites, former schools and former care facilities among them, that private developers had judged commercially unviable and left standing empty, turning disused council land into communities while driving regeneration across the city. A defined share of every scheme was earmarked for affordable housing and for routes into ownership an open-market scheme would never have offered, built by contractors required to deliver local employment, training and apprenticeships alongside the homes themselves, not just the homes on their own. Since WV Living's incorporation in 2016, the programme has delivered 629 new homes, 261 of them affordable, with a further 623 planned over the next five years: a programme scale most councils never attempt directly, rather than handing it to a private developer partner and stepping back. My own relationship with Wolverhampton City Council runs to twelve years, dealing with the council directly since 2014 and with WV Living, the council's own housing company, since its incorporation in 2016.

### The Commercial Translator

The brief was not to run a sales office. It was to sit in the room where council decisions were made and translate them, in both directions, into something a buyer moving into a three-bed semi could actually use. A planning condition, a Section 106 obligation, a grant-funding requirement attached to a shared ownership plot: each one had to become a clear answer to an ordinary question, not a paragraph of policy.

That meant designing the buyer journey almost from nothing: the touchpoints from reservation to completion, the communications that kept a buyer informed without drowning them in process, and the reporting that let the council see, in commercial terms it recognised, that the model was working. None of that infrastructure existed while a housing scheme was still being run as a capital project rather than a sales operation.

### Approach

#### Shared Ownership: Explained, Not Just Offered

Shared ownership plots, including at Hampton Park, alongside Leasowes Farm, The Glade and Vicarage View, were sold directly to buyers who needed the process explained in plain terms, not policy language. The eligibility rules, the staircasing mechanics, the funding conditions attached to a grant-supported plot: none of it meant anything to a buyer until

it was translated into what it actually changed about their move, their mortgage and their monthly cost. Done properly, that translation was the difference between a scheme that sold and one that sat there: for many of these buyers, it was the route into a home they would not otherwise have been able to afford at all.

Part buy, part rent has never been an easy sell on its own terms. It doesn't have the simplicity of a standard mortgage, and it carries a stigma that a straight purchase never has to overcome: the sense of a compromise rather than a choice. Closing that gap took real work, not a leaflet in a sales office. Every member of the sales team was trained to walk a buyer through exactly what they were getting, in language that matched how they actually thought about the decision, not how the funding agreement described it. The homes sold because shared ownership stopped being something a buyer had to be talked into and became something they understood well enough to choose for themselves.

### **Bulk Sale: A Different Conversation Entirely**

Sales agreed with private rented sector investors buying in volume to let ran on an entirely different commercial logic to a single family's moving day. The conversation was about yield, delivery certainty and programme, not show homes and viewing slots: a bulk buyer wanted assurance the pipeline would land on schedule, not a tour of the kitchen finish. Structuring that relationship correctly de-risked the wider scheme, giving WV Living committed volume before a single owner-occupier ever walked a plot.

### **Open Market: Competing on Equal Terms**

The remaining homes across each site were sold on the open market, competing directly against private developers on land the council happened to own. That meant a go-to-market standard, presentation, pricing, sales process, that gave a buyer no reason to treat a WV Living home as a lesser product than a private housebuilder's, and every reason to see the social ambition behind it as a strength rather than a compromise.

### **Working at Two Speeds**

A council sign-off cycle and a buyer's expectations run at fundamentally different speeds, and neither could be allowed to distort the other. Committee timelines, procurement rules and public accountability had to keep running exactly as they should, while a buyer chasing a mortgage offer deadline needed answers in days, not committee cycles. Managing both simultaneously meant building a layer that could absorb the council's pace on one side and translate it into commercial pace on the other, without either side ever having to compromise on what it was actually there to do.

### **Reporting the Council Could Actually Use**

The council's own governance needed visibility that matched its own process, not a sales team's shorthand. Reporting was built to translate sales performance, viewing numbers and pipeline into language a council committee could scrutinise: the same close-to-the-detail discipline that ran through every account, adapted for an audience answerable to the public rather than to a boardroom.

### **One Opinion, Real Cost**

Not every obstacle sat in planning policy or funding rules. A single elected member, holding a strong and firmly expressed view on a point of technical specification, could carry enough political weight to override the guidance of the professionals who actually understood the requirement. Once that instruction reached site, it had to be followed, then subsequently reversed once it became clear the specification was wrong: work undone and redone, cost absorbed twice over for a decision that never needed making in the first place.

The same individual could also raise concerns about cash flow performance, without acknowledging that the delays behind it traced back to decisions exactly like that one. Managing WV Living was never only a construction and sales programme. Managing a single, influential opinion before it became a cost line, and protecting the programme from the gap between what one person believed was right and what the evidence actually supported, was just as much a part of the job.

### **Commercial Outcome**

Six sites sold across three routes to market: shared ownership, bulk sale to private rented sector investors and the open market. Bulk sale gave the council committed volume before a single owner-occupier walked a plot, de-risking the wider programme. Across a twelve-year relationship with Wolverhampton City Council, WV Living has delivered 629 new homes since its 2016 incorporation, 261 of them affordable, with a further 623 planned over the next five years.

### **Customer Outcome**

Every buyer, whether a first-time shared owner or a family buying outright, moved through the same operation without ever feeling they were dealing with a council. Planning conditions, Section 106 obligations and grant rules translated into plain answers to ordinary questions.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-wv-living.html>

# Abbey Place: the Flagship of CBRE's National Fund Portfolio

CBRE Global Investment Management deploys institutional capital into real estate, buying housing from developers at a discount and converting it into shared ownership and affordable rent. This is how that fund's national housing operation was run, not as a sales mandate, but as something closer to a fractional Chief Operating Officer role, headlined by a 500-unit tower at Abbey Place and a scheme at Bletchley sold out entirely off-plan.

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**650+** units delivered across eight sites nationally

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## Situation

CBRE Global Investment Management manages money on behalf of institutional investors, deploying it into real estate. The strategy behind this fund was specific: buy housing units from developers at a discount to open market value, convert them into shared ownership and affordable rent products, then retain the stock as an income-producing asset. Government grant funding, available on those tenures, effectively subsidised part of the conversion cost, which is what let the fund acquire discounted stock and still produce a return its investors would recognise as high-yielding, not merely acceptable.

That model only works if the units are bought right, priced right, and sold at the rate a fund's investors expect, three separate disciplines that don't usually sit with one person. My role wasn't a sales mandate in the way most accounts are. It sat closer to a fractional Chief Operating Officer for the fund's housing operations: involved before a deal was signed, not brought in once the commercial terms were already fixed.

## Approach

### Earning the Mandate on the Fylde Coast

CBRE are fund managers rather than housebuilders, and the trust behind the fractional COO role started on a single stalled site on the Fylde Coast. Another agency had been running sales there and it had stalled: they hadn't recognised the nuances the asset needed, and CBRE's own team didn't have deep in-house knowledge of the sales, marketing and legal process behind it either. The stall wasn't free. Standing stock, built and vacant, carries a real holding cost, and it was hurting performance against the fund's own KPIs, with real exposure to future investment if it wasn't fixed.

That site became my opportunity: brought in on the project from start to finish, more involved in the site set-up than a typical sales mandate, building stronger administrative foundations and cutting the time between milestones. The pace that came from it is what made CBRE receptive to something much bigger: stepping in to set up their entire sales operation nationally, with regular check-ins built into how it ran rather than being handed over unsupervised.

### Sourcing and Advising the Deals

Deals came from two directions: sourced directly and brought to CBRE as opportunities, and evaluated on CBRE's behalf when they found something themselves. Either way, the advice came before a decision to proceed: whether a site's numbers, location and tenure mix actually supported the fund's shared ownership and affordable rent model, not just whether it looked attractive on paper.

### Setting the Commercial Case

Once a deal was approved, the work moved to pricing strategy, marketing strategy and product specification: the three levers that determine whether a converted scheme actually performs the way a fund's model assumes it will. Get the specification wrong for the shared ownership buyer it's aimed at, or price ahead of what the affordable rent market will bear, and the yield the fund reports to its investors never materialises.

### A National Structure

Delivery ran nationally across eight sites, with regional sales managers reporting directly to me on every scheme, the same structure that let a small number of people run a geographically scattered portfolio without losing sight of any single site's performance.

### **Abbey Place: the Flagship**

The flagship of the portfolio was Abbey Place, a 500-unit tower in Abbey Wood, London. Forty-five per cent of the scheme sold off-plan, with the remainder following within around twelve months of completion, a sell-through rate that justified the fund's underwriting on the scheme before a single unit had even been built.

### **Bletchley: Sold Before It Was Built**

At Bletchley in Milton Keynes, a 150-flat scheme sold out entirely off-plan, every unit committed before completion. It is the cleanest possible proof that the pricing and positioning were right: no incentive scramble at completion, no unsold stock sitting on the fund's balance sheet waiting for a buyer.

### **Commercial Outcome**

650-plus units delivered across eight sites. Every scheme performed against the model it was underwritten on, which is the only result that matters to an institutional fund: not one good sale, but a portfolio that behaves exactly as promised.

### **Customer Outcome**

The end product was shared ownership and affordable rent. Specification and pricing were set against what those buyers could actually sustain rather than what the fund's model hoped they could, which is why Bletchley sold out entirely before a single flat was finished.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-cbre.html>

# Octopus Real Estate: the Sales and Compliance Operation, Built From Scratch

Octopus Real Estate, part of a group better known for energy and utilities, chose to deploy capital into housing. This is how the sales operation and the regulatory compliance framework behind it, built to Homes England's Capital Funding Guide, were built from a blank page, with no existing function to inherit, on sites the length of the country, and run through to completion.

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## Full Lifecycle

brought in pre-launch, sites from Bath to North Devon

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### Situation

Octopus Real Estate is the property investment arm of Octopus Energy, a utility provider that chose to deploy capital into housing rather than energy infrastructure alone. The model was straightforward on paper: buy developments from housebuilders, convert them into shared ownership and affordable housing products, and hold the resulting income. In practice it meant becoming, almost overnight, a housing provider bound by rules a utility company had never had to operate under.

The portfolio ran the length of the country: Bath, North London, Northam and Bideford in the South West, and Thornwood in Essex, among a plethora of sites, and I was brought in before any of it was sales-ready. Not to fix a process that already existed, but to build one from a blank page, then run it through to every building's completion.

### The Capital Funding Guide

Shared ownership funded through Homes England's Capital Funding Guide comes with rules that determine who is even allowed to buy, not just how the sale is marketed. Household income is capped at £80,000 a year outside London and £90,000 within it, directly relevant on the North London scheme, where the higher threshold changed who the marketing could target in the first place. Applicants are primarily expected to be first-time buyers, though existing owners can qualify in the right circumstances, and serving armed forces personnel and recently discharged veterans receive priority where supply is limited.

None of that is a box-ticking exercise. The affordability assessment has to establish that a buyer can sustain home ownership long-term, not just afford the initial purchase: savings, other assets and outgoings all examined, not only income. Existing homeowners generally have to sell their current property before or alongside completing a shared ownership purchase. Get any of it wrong and the exposure isn't a difficult conversation with a buyer, it's a compliance finding against a government-funded programme.

### Approach

#### Winning the Mandate Before the Brief Existed

The instruction didn't arrive out of a competitive pitch against agents who already knew Octopus's plans. It came out of early engagement with Octopus before the brief itself was fully formed, built on case studies from other regulated, compliance-heavy housing mandates that showed the discipline this role needed had already been proven elsewhere, not something that would be learned for the first time on Octopus's own portfolio. That track record is what let a utility company entering housing for the first time trust an outside operator with building the function from nothing, rather than hiring internally and learning as they went.

#### Building the Go-to-Market Strategy From Nothing

There was no existing sales function to inherit, so the brief started with a blank page: go-to-market strategy, branding, pricing and specification for every scheme, built before a single unit went on sale. Sales delivery followed, and ran through

to completion on every site, not handed off once the launch was done.

## **Proving Compliance, Not Just Managing It**

Understanding what the Capital Funding Guide actually required was only half the job. The other half was building the audit trail that proved it: records showing every buyer had been assessed correctly, every rent-to-unsold-equity percentage held to what was agreed at initial allocation, every scheme ready to withstand scrutiny from Homes England without a scramble to reconstruct the paperwork after the fact. That protection is what let a utility company new to housing operate with the confidence of one that had been doing it for years.

## **A National Portfolio, Run From the North West**

Every site sat hundreds of miles from home, Bath, North London, Northam, Bideford, and none of it was managed any less closely for the distance. Regional oversight, frequent and accurate reporting, and enough personal visibility on each site meant a problem in the South West was never a surprise discovered from the North West.

## **The Commercial Lens Behind the Compliance**

A mandate this regulated could easily have narrowed into pure administration. It didn't, because the compliance discipline sat underneath a genuinely commercial operation: pricing and specification decisions were tested against what the affordability rules would actually allow a buyer to pay, not set first and reconciled with the rules afterward. Go-to-market strategy was built to match what the business could actually deliver on-site, not what looked ambitious on a slide. That alignment between strategic intent and operational capacity, held together with the same stakeholder management and personal accountability any managing director's brief would demand, is the difference between running a sales function and running a business.

## **Commercial Outcome**

Account retained on the same terms as the group's most established housing clients, on a national portfolio built from a blank page and run from the North West. Sales completed or in delivery span:

- 82 units at Northam and Bideford (£21m GDV)
- The 68-unit sale element of the wider Bluebell portfolio (£22m GDV)
- 12 units at Great Haddon (£36.5m GDV)
- 35 homes at Carpenters Yard in Essex (£21m GDV), due for completion in late 2026

Contract value on the units sold to date stands at c.£600,000, before Carpenters Yard completes.

## **Customer Outcome**

Affordability assessed against whether a buyer could sustain ownership long term rather than merely afford the purchase. Income caps applied correctly, priority honoured for first-time buyers and armed forces personnel, and an audit trail that proved it before Homes England ever asked.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-octopus-real-estate.html>

# The Victoria, Glasgow: Winning the Anchor That Turned a Region Around

A failing Scottish business unit needed more than restructuring to recover, it needed proof, in the market, that it deserved to be trusted with a client's most significant site. This is how two smaller wins became the proving ground for the pitch that won it: a 413-home redevelopment of the former Victoria Infirmary in Glasgow, taken from Savills.

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## 413 Homes full masterplan for the former Victoria Infirmary, Langside

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### Situation

The Scotland business unit was already mid-turnaround by the time the Victoria became a possibility. The cost base had been rebuilt, the management layer restructured, and every contract audited for what was genuinely unsellable against what was simply mispriced or under-marketed. What that restructuring alone couldn't do was prove, externally, that the unit deserved to be trusted with a client's most significant instruction.

A leaner cost base convinces an internal board. It does nothing for a client deciding who gets their best site. That needed a genuine anchor win, not just better numbers, and the client whose trust mattered most was Sanctuary, the same national account already run across sites the length of the UK.

### Proving the Team First

Sanctuary wasn't approached cold about its most significant Scottish site. Two smaller instructions came first, deliberately used as a test of exactly what a rebuilt Scottish operation could deliver: Love Street in Paisley, the former St Mirren football ground, and Chase Park in Ellesmere Port, a former greyhound track. Both sold out completely: Love Street's 132 homes, the majority for affordable social rent alongside a share sold through New Supply Shared Equity, and Chase Park's share of a 141-home scheme delivered alongside homes for Cheshire West and Chester Council and a private-rented-sector investor.

That wasn't incidental. It was the proof of span and control a client needs before handing over an instruction they actually care about: evidence the sales process worked at a distance, not just under close personal supervision, and evidence it worked on two very different sites, a repurposed sports ground and a repurposed industrial site, not just one favourable location.

### The Pitch

The Victoria was a must-win, and the competition wasn't soft. Savills, one of the most entrenched national agents in the market, was the incumbent expectation for a site this significant, the safe choice, the name a housing association's board would never be criticised for picking. Winning meant not just matching that credibility but making the difference in ambition impossible to miss.

The pitch itself was built to be remembered rather than merely delivered. Hard-copy presentation books replaced a screen, because a document a decision-maker could hold and pass around a boardroom table outlasts a slide nobody reopens. The material itself was emotive rather than purely technical: the area's own history, the community's connection to a hospital that had shaped Langside for generations, a redevelopment framed as continuing that story rather than erasing it. The presentation was led with values, both the business's own and Sanctuary's, before a single commercial number was mentioned, because the numbers alone were never going to be what separated the pitch from Savills'. Every stakeholder in the room was drilled and rehearsed until the delivery was as tight as the material itself, nothing left to whether someone happened to be having a good day.

### Testing the Market, Then Committing

Sanctuary didn't award the Victoria off the back of the pitch alone. They paused, and instructed Love Street and Chase Park first: a live test of whether the capability in the room matched the capability on paper. Both sold out. Only then was the Victoria instructed: the outcome of proof gathered on two separate sites, not persuasion gathered in one room.

## **Anchoring the Market, Not Just the P&L**

Taken at breakeven in phase one as a deliberate market-position decision, with terms renegotiated once that position was proven. Establishing the business as the dominant player in Glasgow's residential development sales market was the thing that actually mattered, a position that would generate returns for years, not just on this one contract. Market position first, margin second.

## **Commercial Outcome**

The group's pitch win of the year, taken from Savills: £115m of GDV and £1.65m in fee value, run at breakeven in phase one as a deliberate market-position decision and renegotiated once that position was proven. It anchored the recovery of a unit that had been earmarked for closure, and the result led directly to promotion to Divisional Director.

## **Customer Outcome**

135 affordable homes in phase one of a 413-home masterplan that retained the former hospital's Nightingale wards, on a site the community had a century of attachment to. The pitch led with what the redevelopment would mean for Langside before it mentioned a commercial number.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-victoria.html>

# The Tobacco Warehouse: Seven Years to Win the Biggest Mandate the Business Ever Landed

The world's largest brick-built building, standing on Stanley Dock beside the site of Everton's new stadium at Bramley-Moore Dock. A seven-year pursuit, through planning, redesign and constant reconfiguration, for the single largest instruction the business had ever seen on offer.

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**500+ Units** the single largest instruction the business has ever won, at Stanley Dock

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## Situation

Some buildings are simply the crème de la crème, and the Tobacco Warehouse is one of them. Built in 1901 on Liverpool's Stanley Dock, it is the largest brick-built building on earth: fourteen storeys, 1.6 million square feet, 27 million bricks, a Grade II-listed structure so vast and so photogenic it has become one of the city's most filmed backdrops, most recently as the beating heart of Netflix's House of Guinness. It sits a few hundred metres from Bramley-Moore Dock, where Everton were building their new stadium, in a corner of the docklands that was rapidly becoming the most watched regeneration story in the city.

Converting it into apartments was never going to be simple, and it wasn't meant to be won quickly. The instruction on offer, once it finally landed, was for 500-plus apartments on a fee scale that made it the largest single mandate the business had ever landed, before a single pound of attachment sales income or the publicity value of being named on the most talked-about address in Liverpool. It was, without argument, the single largest mandate the business had ever had the chance to win in one go. Getting it meant surviving seven years of a process most people would have walked away from in the first eighteen months.

## Staying in the Room for Free

A landmark instruction like this doesn't move through a single pitch meeting. It moves through years of planning committees, revised massing, reconfigured unit mixes, and a developer testing every agent in the room long before any instruction is actually signed. That testing has a name in the trade, and it isn't flattering: being bled for information. Strategic input, market data, pricing logic, sales-strategy thinking: all of it handed over meeting after meeting, year after year, with no guarantee any of it would ever convert into a fee.

The choice was to stay anyway. Every meeting attended, every request for insight answered properly rather than guarded, backing the relationship on the belief that being consistently useful for free was the only route to being trusted with the instruction when it was finally ready to be placed. Competitors circled throughout, some for a year, some for two, and dropped away when the return on their patience didn't show up fast enough. Seven years is a long time to keep believing a building will eventually be yours to sell.

## Courting Dublin

The developer behind Stanley Dock's regeneration is Irish, headquartered in Dublin, and the people who mattered most to the pursuit weren't only in Liverpool: they were the developer's own principals, wealthy and understandably guarded about who they let close to a building of this significance. Winning their confidence meant multiple trips to Ireland, sitting across the table from people used to being courted by everyone and impressed by very few of them, and doing it repeatedly over years rather than once, well, in a single pitch.

That relationship was the actual instruction being won, long before a single apartment was ever marketed. A building this iconic was never going to be handed to whoever pitched hardest on the day. It was going to go to whoever the developer's own people trusted enough, after years of contact, to put their name on Liverpool's most significant sales instruction.

## Two Markets, One Sales Strategy

Winning the instruction was only the start of the commercial problem. A building this large needed a sales strategy that could run two fundamentally different markets at once: overseas investors, drawn to a landmark asset with a story attached to it, bought through international roadshows and repeat trips to present the opportunity directly; and domestic buyers, moving through a very different journey entirely: mortgage-dependent, price-sensitive, and reliant on government schemes like Help to Buy to make an off-plan purchase in a heritage conversion actually affordable. Running both simultaneously, without either undermining the other on price or pace, was its own piece of design work, built specifically for a building where the two buyer types would ultimately be living side by side.

## Commercial Outcome

The single largest mandate the business has ever landed: £175m of GDV and £2.875m in fee value. 500-plus apartments, plus attachment sales income and the publicity value of being named on the city's most recognisable address. Seven years of staying in the room, being useful without being paid for it, and repeated trips to Dublin to earn trust the pitch deck alone was never going to buy.

## Customer Outcome

Two entirely different buyer journeys designed to run side by side without either undermining the other: overseas investors buying a landmark asset, and domestic, mortgage-dependent buyers relying on government schemes to make an off-plan heritage purchase achievable.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-tobacco-warehouse.html>

# Barnes Village: Building a Premium Brand Around a Listed Hospital London Couldn't Deliver Alone

Henley Homes, a London developer based out of Battersea, had bought one of South Manchester's most recognisable landmarks. What they hadn't bought, until a fractional sales director joined the project, was the local intensity of care the brand they wanted to build actually required.

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**£1.35m** fee value secured on 156 homes, Grade II listed, sold at record local price points

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## Situation

Barnes Hospital in Cheadle wasn't just another listed building. Founded in 1875 by the Victorian philanthropist Robert Barnes as a convalescent home and respiratory treatment centre, its French Gothic Revival tower had stood over the town for well over a century and closed as a hospital in 1999, becoming exactly the kind of landmark local residents feel proprietorial about: the building everyone in Cheadle has an opinion on, whatever gets done with it. Henley Homes, a developer headquartered in Battersea, London, bought the 16.5-acre site with a clear brief: convert the original Victorian hospital building into a collection of apartments, and build new houses across the remainder of the grounds, 156 homes in total.

What became apparent once the deal had completed was a gap between ambition and delivery. Henley Homes wanted the finished product to be immaculate, genuinely, unqualified, one hundred percent immaculate, specification and presentation built around interior designers rather than a standard developer showhome package. That level of hand-holding, the sustained local attention a heritage-led premium brand actually needs, wasn't something a London-based team could run at arm's length on a site 200 miles north. The gap between the brand they were trying to build and the operation on the ground is what created the instruction.

## Brought In to Close the Gap

The role was fractional sales director rather than a full-time hire, embedded enough to run the commercial side of the project properly, without Henley Homes carrying a permanent Manchester-based sales leadership function they didn't otherwise need. That meant owning specification decisions alongside the interior design team, protecting the immaculate standard the brand depended on at every stage from show-apartment fit-out to the finish on the final townhouse, and being the person on the ground translating a London board's ambition into decisions made correctly, day to day, on a site they weren't standing on.

## Positioning a Premium Product South Manchester Hadn't Seen

The commercial strategy started from a decision not to price Barnes Village against the rest of Cheadle. A building with this history and this level of finish wasn't a like-for-like comparable to the new-build schemes around it, and pricing it as one would have capped it at exactly the ceiling the immaculate specification was designed to break through. Instead, the building's own story, its French Gothic tower, its Victorian scale, the fact nothing like it would ever be built again, was made the actual product being sold, with the interior specification built to match rather than undercut that positioning. It worked: price points were achieved that South Manchester's market simply hadn't seen before on a comparable scheme.

## The Plot Strategy Behind the Price Points

Record prices don't happen by accident, and they don't happen by releasing every plot on day one. The apartments inside the old hospital building, the most singular product on the site, were held back from the earliest release phases rather than sold alongside the standard new-build houses, a deliberate sequencing decision that let the market absorb and re-price around the ordinary stock first, before the genuinely unique units were ever tested against it. Each subsequent release was priced up from the last sold comparable, not down to move volume, and a small number of the very best plots, the

largest apartments, the townhouses with the strongest outlook over the grounds, were held back from sale entirely until demand had proven itself, rather than released at a price nobody had yet validated. That's the actual mechanism behind a record price point: not one clever number, but controlling exactly which product the market sees, and when, so every sale sets the floor for the next one rather than the ceiling.

## **Commercial Outcome**

£1.35m of fee value on 156 homes, at price points South Manchester had not seen on a comparable heritage conversion, achieved through release sequencing rather than a single pricing decision.

## **Customer Outcome**

A finished product held to a genuinely immaculate standard, from show-apartment fit-out through to the last townhouse, because the building's history was the product being sold and buyers were paying precisely for that.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-barnes-village.html>